

TAKEOUT DOUBLES

ABOUT THE DEALS

You will always be in the South position. Either you or partner may be the Takeout Doubler.

(Strictly speaking a Takeout Double is a **CALL**, not a bid, so the term is used loosely here.)

TAKEOUT DOUBLE SUMMARY

Note that the following really is just a Summary, not a full-blown lesson.

The Takeout Double is one of the oldest conventions in Bridge.
In it's simplest form it means "Partner, I have a good hand, please pick a suit."

It is necessary that you and partner agree on when a double is for takeout, and when it is not.
Here are some suggestions:

- The bid that is doubled is a suit bid, not notrump.
- Neither the Doubler nor his partner have made any call other than pass.
- The bid that has been doubled is below game level.

There are three categories of Takeout Double.

- The classic one where you have opening strength and support for all unbid suits.
- The one-suited hand which is too strong for an overcall.
- The notrump type hand which is too strong for a non-jump notrump overcall.

Here are the various guidelines:

Classic	• 13+ points* • no more than 2 cards in doubled suit • at least 3 cards in the other suits
One-suited	• 17 or more points • a quality suit 5 cards or longer
Notrump	• balanced notrump type hand • more than 18 points • good stoppers in doubled suit

* When evaluating your hand for a Classic TO Double you may count short-suit points, just as if you were responding to partner's opening bid. The idea is that partner will be choosing a suit which you can support. Don't go overboard though, because partner really hasn't bid that suit yet!

You may disagree with all these guidelines, many will. By all means stick to yours. But if your partnership doesn't have an agreement then these are a good start. They are here because the Deals that follow are based on them.

Classic Double:

The partner of the Takeout Doubler should assume that the double is of the Classic type because it usually will be. Then, if Doubler later indicates one of the other types he can adjust.

Partner's actions are as follows:

- 0-8 points or fewer - bid a suit at the cheapest level
- 9-11 points - jump in a suit
- 12+ points - cuebid the opponent's suit; forcing to game
- 8-10 points - bid notrump at cheapest level if balanced and with a stopper in opponent's suit
- 11-12 points - jump in notrump if balanced and with 1+ stoppers in opponent's suit
- 13-15 points - bid 3NT if balanced and with 2 stoppers in opponent's suit
- "some" points - pass for penalties holding 6 good cards in opponent's suit; partner is expected to lead a trump

The Doubler's next bid will be a natural bid dependent on his partner's response to the double. The 0-8 point range is the largest spread and so creates the largest problem for the Doubler, who should proceed cautiously.

One-suited Double

If Doubler ignores partner's choice of a suit and bids his own suit that indicates he has the 17+ point type of Takeout Double. It shows an Overcalling type of hand, but one which is too strong to Overcall. Responder should then bid naturally based on the knowledge of Doubler's hand which is known to contain a good 5+ card suit.

Notrump

Holding a 15-18 point balanced hand with a good stopper in the opponent's suit you would just overcall 1NT.

You show a 19+ point balanced hand by first doubling, then bidding notrump. Partner should proceed just as if you had opened 2NT.

Opener's Partner bids:

If your partner makes a Takeout Double and the next player says anything other than pass then you are no longer required to bid. This is because your partner gets another chance to bid and doesn't have to let the opponents play the doubled (or perhaps redoubled) contract. So if you **do** bid in this situation it is called a "free bid", one that you weren't forced to make. With a bad hand you would probably just pass, but if you have a distinct suit preference you should say so immediately rather than waiting until the bidding gets to a high level.

The topic really merits another 25,000 words.
Instead we have 25 examples.

Board: 1
Dealer: **East**
Contract: 3♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♦ K

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 2♥
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦ K

Board: 3
Dealer: **South**
Contract: 2♦
Declarer: South
Lead: ♦ 6

Board: 4
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 5♣
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦ 4

Board: 5
Dealer: **North**
Contract: 1♣
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣ 7

Board 1

East Deals

None Vul

♠ Q 10 7 3
♥ 9 5 4
♦ A 7 3
♣ 10 9 2

♠ J 9 6 5

♥ 8 7 3

♦ 8 4

♣ A 8 6 4

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ K 2

♥ A 10 2

♦ K Q J 10 6 5

♣ 5 3

♠ A 8 4

♥ K Q J 6

♦ 9 2

♣ K Q J 7

West

North

East

South

1 ♠

Pass

1 ♦

Dbl

Pass

3 ♣

2 ♦

Dbl

All Pass

3 ♣ by North

Lead: ♦ K

The bidding has been as shown.

Now that West has stolen your response you aren't strong enough to make a free-bid at the 2-level. You pass, East bids 2 ♦ and partner doubles again. Now what?

This is not a penalty double, partner is merely repeating his request for you to name a suit. But now he expects you to choose between ♥s and ♣s.

You bid 3 ♣ and everybody passes.

You may be one too high, but that still might be a good score if they can make 2 ♦.

Board 2

South Deals

N-S Vul

♠ A 9 7 5

♥ K J 3

♦ 9 7

♣ K Q 5 2

♠ K Q J 10 4 2

♥ A 4 2

♦ 10 5

♣ 10 7



♠ 8 3

♥ Q 10 9 6 5

♦ 8 4 2

♣ A 8 4

♠ 6

♥ 8 7

♦ A K Q J 6 3

♣ J 9 6 3

The bidding has been as shown.

After North bids you are no longer forced to respond to partner's Takeout Double. You may pass if you want to.

But if you don't pass you are making what is called a "free bid". You should have 6 or more points and a reason for wanting to bid - like your 5-card ♥ suit.

You bid 2♥ and everybody passes.

*West**North**East**South*

Dbl

1♠

2♥

1♦

All Pass

2♥ by East

Lead: ♦K

Board 3

South Deals

E-W Vul

♠ K 8 7 3

♥ K J 4

♦ 7 6

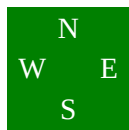
♣ A Q 5 2

♠ J 9 6

♥ A 10 8

♦ A 10 3

♣ J 10 8 4



♠ 5 4

♥ Q 9 7 5 2

♦ 9 5 2

♣ 7 6 3

♠ A Q 10 2

♥ 6 3

♦ K Q J 8 4

♣ K 9

West

North

East

South

Dbl

Rdbl

1♥

Pass

Pass

2♦

All Pass

2♦ by South

Lead: ♦6

The bidding has been as shown.

The redouble has taken the force from you - you can pass if you want to. But if you pass, the most likely scenario is that South will also pass. So partner will either have to let them play 1♦ redoubled (which will be a disaster for your side) or take out his own double by bidding some suit. So he will bid a suit and it will almost surely be 1♠.

You can help your side the most by bidding 1♥ immediately. You don't have to worry that partner will believe you have a good hand; both he and South have 13+ points and North's redouble shows 10 or more. He knows there are no points remaining for you to have.

On this deal your ♥ bid gets passed around to North who bids 2♦, the final contract.

Board 4

North Deals

Both Vul

♠ 3
 ♥ K Q
 ♦ Q J 10 6 2
 ♣ K Q 10 8 4

♠ A 5 4
 ♥ A J 10 6 5 3
 ♦ 8 5 4
 ♣ 7



♠ K 10 9 7
 ♥ 8
 ♦ A K 7 3
 ♣ A J 9 6

♠ Q J 8 6 2
 ♥ 9 7 4 2
 ♦ 9
 ♣ 5 3 2

West	North	East	South
	2♥	Dbl	Pass
3♥	Pass	3♠	Pass
4♣	Pass	5♣	
All Pass			
5♣ by West			
Lead: ♦4			

The bidding has been as shown.

The problem with making a Takeout Double of a preemptive bid is that the bidding for your side starts out a level or two higher. So you can't risk doubling with a flimsy hand. However, this hand is certainly good enough so you double. Partner responds 3♥.

After partner cuebids the next job is to find a suit, so you bid 3♠. Partner now bids 4♣.

You cannot stop short of game. Partner has apparently rejected your ♠ suggestion. Since you are happy to play in ♣s you bid 5♣.

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ K 9
♥ 8 5
♦ Q 6 2
♣ Q J 10 9 6 3

♠ J 7 3 2
♥ K Q J 10
♦ A 4
♣ K 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A Q 8 6
♥ A 7 4 2
♦ K J 10 5
♣ 7

♠ 10 5 4
♥ 9 6 3
♦ 9 8 7 3
♣ A 8 4

*West**North**East**South*

1 ♣

Dbl

All Pass

1 ♣ by North

Lead: ♣ 7

The bidding has been as shown.

You could certainly say 1NT if you wanted to. You have 8 HCP and a very good ♣ stopper. However, you will probably make a lot more points by letting them play 1 ♣ doubled.

This is exactly the kind of hand you need to pass and convert partner's Takeout Double to a Penalty Double. Partner should lead a ♣ so you can pull declarer's trumps as soon as possible.